

staying active eight to 12 hours a day. At higher levels of activity, people balance their caloric intake and expenditure pretty well."

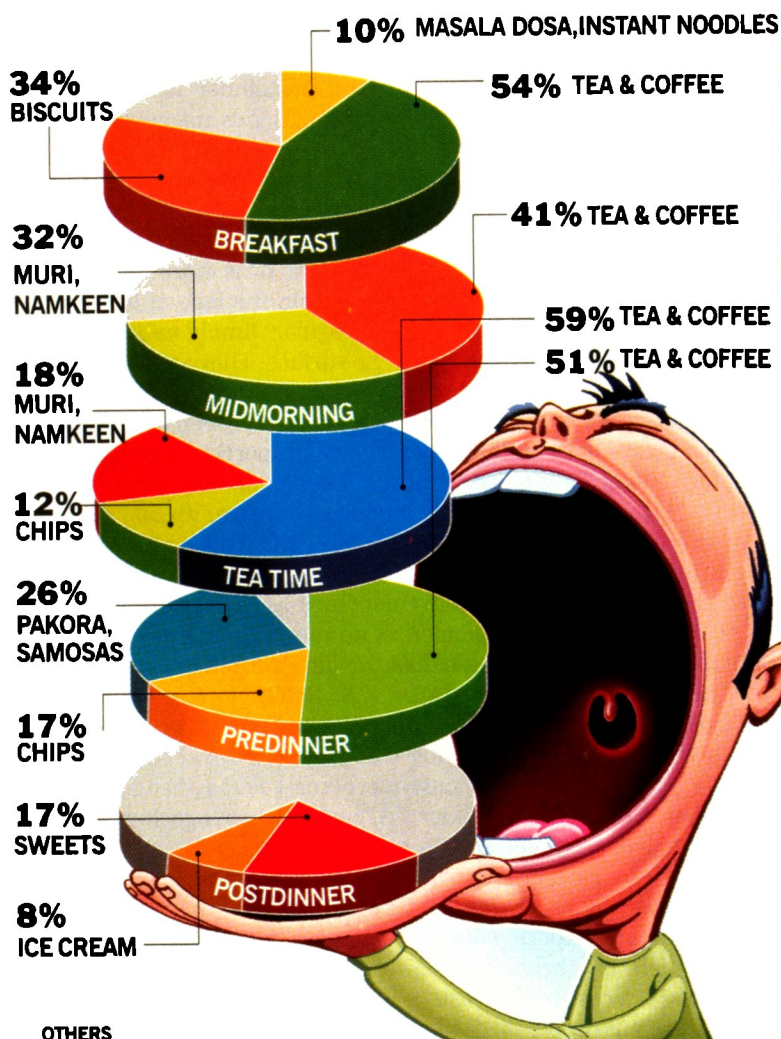
Today, food obtrudes itself constantly, seductively, into our lives—on sidewalks, in malls and multiplexes, through television. The pungent aromas of quick-food emporiums waft everywhere; store shelves are chock-a-block with mass-produced, calorie-packed food. "It's difficult to resist the temptation if they are available," points out Dr Anoop Misra, Director and Head, Department of Diabetes and Metabolic Diseases, Fortis Hospital, Delhi. "We eat lots of sugar, we eat between meals, we eat everywhere and at all times—at work, at play, and in transit." There's also enormous pressure on homes in urban India, with both the husband and wife often in the work force. This means, there is less time to cook healthy meals, more eating out, grabbing takeout food, or buying frozen foods to heat up at home. "There really is a time issue—people do have less time," says Misra.

"Mindless eating" is now the name of the game. Coined to explain why so many people eat so much,



Photographs by HEMANT CHAWLA

SPOT YOUR UNHEALTHY FOODS



DIET DANGER

We overeat because of boredom, family and friends, packages and plates, shapes and smells.

by Dr Brian Wansink of Cornell University in his 2006 non-fiction: *Mindless Eating: Why we Eat More Than we Think*, the term has become the leit-motif in America's fight against obesity. People are constantly getting "trapped" by their surroundings into eating calories more than they need or want, writes Wansink. "We don't overeat because we are hungry or because the food tastes that good," he holds. We overeat because of boredom, of family and friends, packages and plates, shapes and smells, distractions and distances. "The list is as endless as it is invisible." He has also found that people make more than 200 decisions about food every day, including what and when to eat, how many bites to take of different foods and whether to get second helpings. "We just don't realise this and that's what leads to mindless mistakes." The